Today we turn to our third big question. This question can be introduced by an example.

Suppose that in the year 2069 the surviving members of this Introduction to Philosophy class decided to have an Intro to Philosophy reunion, and all gathered in this room. Suppose that they decided to get a group picture taken.

Now imagine that, via some sort of time travel device, I now have that photo, and show it to you. You might ask: Am I one of those people? Which one am I?

It is very natural to assume that these questions must have determinate answers. There must be some fact of the matter about whether one of the people in the photo is you. And, if one is you, there must be some fact of the matter about which one is you.

Let’s suppose that this is true: there must be a fact about whether you survive to be in this picture, and must be a fact about which of the survivors you are.

Then we can ask a question about these facts:

The survival question: What does it take for for some person at some other time to be you?

To introduce our main answers to the survival question, it will be useful to think about a simple, uncontroversial example of survival.

All of you believe that you will wake up tomorrow in your bed. To put the same point another way, all of you believe that the person now sitting in your seat is the same person as — identical to — the person who will wake up in your bed tomorrow morning.

What do we mean when we say that you are identical to that person?

Here it is important to get clear at the outset on one distinction which, if not attended to, can make these questions more confusing than they have to be. This is the distinction between **numerical** and **qualitative** identity.

To say that x and y are numerically identical is to say that they are literally the same thing — they are one, not two.

To say that x and y things are qualitatively identical is to say that they are exactly resembling — they have just the same properties.

When we say that you are identical to the person who will get out of your bed tomorrow morning, we are not of course saying that you are qualitatively identical to that person. Their hair will be messed up, and they will be wearing different clothes.

Rather, we mean that you are numerically identical to that person: there is just **one** person who is today in this class, and is tomorrow morning in that bed.

But then we can ask the survival question: what makes you numerically the same person as the person who will wake up in that bed?

In a moment we will begin looking at some answers to the survival question. But first let's ask a question: given some different answers to the survival question, how can we tell which one is correct?

This focus on numerical identity is not just an arbitrary choice. Intuitively, this is the question we care about. When we ask about whether life after death is possible, we are not asking whether after your death someone will exist who has the same properties as you. We are asking whether **you** — this very individual — will exist. And to ask this is to ask whether someone numerically identical to you could then exist.

Rather, we mean that you are numerically identical to that person: there is just **one** person who is today in this class, and is tomorrow morning in that bed.

The main answer to this question is what we might call the **method of cases**. We look at particular examples, and ask whether the theory in question yields the correct result about whether the person in the example survives or not. We do, after all, often have pretty clear ideas about whether or not an individual survives some event. If a theory implied that the person who sat down in that seat at the beginning of lecture was distinct from the person sitting there now, that theory would be pretty clearly false.

As you will see, when employing this method we sometimes look at actual examples — examples of things that really happened. But sometimes we look at possible examples — examples of things which could happen, but have not actually happened. Why do we do this?

There are two reasons. First, when we ask the survival question we are interested in whether survival in certain circumstances is possible. For example: is it possible to survive the death and decay of my body?

Second, we are asking what survival **is**. And questions about the nature of some thing should explain what is and is not possible regarding that thing.

Here’s an example. Suppose that someone proposed the theory that for an action to be right is for it to make the agent happy.

One might argue against this via an example. Imagine that you are walking around the lakes, and see a child drowning in the shallow water. As it happens, getting your pants wet makes you quite unhappy. And yet it seems obvious that the right action is saving the child.

This looks like a pretty good argument against our theory. Does it matter that this is just a possible example, and never really happened?

It doesn't seem to matter. A theory about what right action is should apply to actions which could happen but haven't as well as actions which have actually happened. The same goes for answers to the survival question.

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